

ABC CONSULTANTS LTD.

HIGHER EDUCATION SUPPORT POLICY – INDIA

Policy Version: 1.0

Effective Date: 1-1-2026

Approved By: JL7 – Executive Leadership

Applies To: India-based permanent employees of ABC Consultants Ltd.

1. PURPOSE

ABC Consultants Ltd. believes that continuous learning and advanced education are critical to building future-ready talent, leadership capability, and deep domain expertise.

This policy aims to:

- Encourage employees to pursue **higher education** aligned with business needs
- Support **PhD and non-PhD academic programs** through structured leave and financial assistance
- Balance employee development with organizational continuity
- Establish a fair, transparent, and governed framework for approvals and benefits

2. SCOPE & APPLICABILITY

This policy applies to:

- Permanent employees on India payroll
- Employees pursuing **recognized higher education programs** in India or abroad
- Job Levels **JL3–JL7**, subject to eligibility and approval

Exclusions:

- Short-term certifications, workshops, or MOOCs (covered under Learning & Development policy)
- Interns, trainees, apprentices, and contract staff

3. DEFINITIONS

Term	Definition
Higher Education	Degree programs beyond undergraduate level
PhD Program	Doctoral research program recognized by UGC / foreign equivalent
Non-PhD Program	Master's, Executive, or Postgraduate degree
Sabbatical Leave	Long-term approved absence for academic pursuit
Bond Period	Mandatory service commitment post-support
Academic Institution	UGC / AICTE / Government-recognized institute

4. ELIGIBLE PROGRAMS

4.1 PhD Programs

Eligible PhD programs must:

- Be recognized by **UGC or equivalent international authority**
 - Be aligned to company-relevant areas such as:
 - Technology, AI, Data Science
 - Management, Leadership, Strategy
 - Domain-specific research aligned to company business
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4.2 Non-PhD Programs

Eligible non-PhD programs include:

- Master's degrees (M.Tech, MS, MBA, M.Sc, etc.)
- Executive or part-time postgraduate programs
- Programs relevant to current or future roles

Programs not aligned to business relevance may be declined.

5. ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

Criteria	Requirement
Minimum service	2 years (Non-PhD), 3 years (PhD)
Performance	Meets or exceeds expectations
Employment status	Confirmed permanent employee
Discipline record	No active disciplinary action

6. MODES OF SUPPORT

ABC Consultants Ltd. may extend one or more of the following forms of support:

1. Sabbatical Leave
 2. Part-Time Study Support / Flexible Work
 3. Academic Leave / Exam Leave
 4. Financial Assistance
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7. SABBATICAL LEAVE FOR HIGHER EDUCATION

Regardless of the university selected, the Company will provide the following support to employees who qualify to pursue a PhD program under this policy:

- Employees in PL4 and above will be granted sabbatical leave during the first year of enrollment to complete coursework, if mandated by the university.
- A leave benefit of up to one year may be availed. The employee must obtain approval in accordance with the extended leave policy.

7.1 Duration

Program Type	Maximum Sabbatical
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PhD	Up to 12 months
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Program Type Maximum Sabbatical

Non-PhD Up to **6 months**

Extension beyond limits requires **JL7 approval only**.

7.2 Sabbatical Leave Pay Structure

Type	Pay Status
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First 6 months	Unpaid
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Remaining period Unpaid / Partially paid (case-specific)

Sabbatical leave **does not count toward service continuity** for gratuity or bonus unless explicitly approved.

7.3 Sabbatical Conditions

- Clear academic plan required
 - Periodic progress updates to HR
 - No external employment allowed
 - Return-to-service obligation mandatory
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8. PART-TIME & FLEXIBLE STUDY SUPPORT

For employees pursuing education **while continuing employment**.

8.1 Flexible Work Arrangements

May include:

- Reduced working hours
- Work-from-home days
- Flexible start/end timings

Subject to manager approval and business needs.

8.2 Academic / Exam Leave

Category	Entitlement
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Exam preparation	Up to 10 days/year
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Thesis submission	Up to 15 days (PhD only)
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Academic leave is **paid** but cannot be accumulated or encashed.

9. FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE

9.1 Coverage Components

Financial support may include:

- Tuition / course fees
- Examination fees
- Registration fees

Excluded:

- Travel, accommodation, books, devices
- Living expenses

9.2 Financial Support Limits (India)

Program	Max Support
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PhD	₹3,00,000 total
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Non-PhD	₹2,00,000 total
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Paid on reimbursement basis against valid receipts. For most Programmes, reimbursement is given after successful completion of the Programme. Employees need to submit original fee paid receipts and proof of successful completion of the Programme, within three months from the date of completion of the Programme and claim reimbursement of fees to claim portal.

There are a few Programmes where reimbursements are done on a yearly basis. Employees need to submit original fee paid receipts and transcripts (marks sheets) as proof of having successfully completed the relevant semester / year; within three months from the date of announcement of results and claim reimbursement of fees.

If the Employee leaves the organization within one year from the date of claiming reimbursement, the entire amount paid as reimbursement will be recovered from the Employee.

9.3 Disbursement Structure

- Annual or semester-wise reimbursement
- Subject to academic progress confirmation

10. SERVICE BOND & RECOVERY

10.1 Mandatory Service Commitment

Support Availed	Bond Period
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Sabbatical	2 years
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Financial assistance	1–2 years
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10.2 Recovery Clause

If employee resigns before bond completion:

- Pro-rata recovery of financial assistance
- Recovery of paid leave benefits (if applicable)

11. APPROVAL MATRIX

Program / Benefit	Recommending Authority	Final Approver
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Non-PhD (within limits)	JL5 / JL6	JL6
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Program / Benefit	Recommending Authority Final Approver	
PhD Program	JL6	JL7
Sabbatical Leave	JL6	JL7
Financial exception	JL6	JL7
Policy deviation	—	JL7

JL7 is the final authority for all higher-education-related decisions.

12. ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

12.1 Employee

- Submit academic proposal
- Maintain performance standards
- Share progress updates

12.2 Reporting Manager

- Assess role impact
- Support knowledge transfer

12.3 HR

- Policy governance
- Agreement & bond administration
- Compliance monitoring

12.4 JL7 (Executive Leadership)

- Strategic approval
 - Exception handling
 - Policy oversight
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13. MISUSE & DISCIPLINARY ACTION

- Misrepresentation of academic progress may lead to withdrawal of benefits
 - Non-compliance may attract disciplinary action
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14. CONFIDENTIALITY & IP

- Any research conducted during employment may be subject to company IP policy
 - Confidential information must not be disclosed to academic institutions
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15. POLICY EXCEPTIONS

All exceptions:

- Must be documented
 - Must include business justification
 - Require **JL7 approval only**
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16. POLICY REVIEW & AMENDMENTS

- Reviewed every 2 years or earlier if required
 - Amendments approved by JL7
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17. Discontinuation or Extension of Programme

Discontinuation:

If an employee chooses to discontinue or withdraw from the course at any point after applying for “Registration” under this policy, they must immediately inform HES, ETA Bangalore so that the registration can be cancelled.

Extension:

If an extension of the course duration is required—for reasons such as onsite assignment, other official commitments, medical circumstances, or maternity leave—the employee must notify the Higher Education Section, ETA Bangalore and obtain approval from the respective DM before proceeding with the deputation or posting. The employee must also communicate the expected date of resuming the Programme. In

such cases, any additional amount paid by the employee beyond the normal fees will be reimbursed along with the final reimbursement.

Not Qualifying:

If an employee fails to qualify or chooses to extend or repeat the course due to personal reasons, no reimbursement will be provided for expenses incurred for the semester, exams not qualified, not attempted, or marked as absent.

18. GOVERNING LAW

This policy is governed by the laws of India.

19. CONTACT

For clarifications:

HR – ABC Consultants Ltd.